



▶ NARESH MHASKE, *54*

| SHIV SENA | ***Thane, Maharashtra***

Like Eknath Shinde, he was among the Shiv Sainiks mentored by Anand Dighe, who exerted talismanic sway over supporters in Thane. Unlike Shinde, Mhaske had never been able to realise his ambition of becoming an MLA. Becoming Thane's mayor twice (2012, 2017) had been the pinnacle for this former youth wing activist. That changed when Shinde's Sena fought off the BJP's claims on its heartland zone—it became even more of a prestige fight against Sena (UBT) pick Rajan Vichare. Mhaske kept factional honour intact.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

▲ ANITA NAGAR SINGH CHAUHAN, *39*

| BJP | ***Ratlam (ST), MP***

She owns a 0.315 rifle and has a 12 bore shotgun licence too—among the few female lawmakers in MP to have arms licences. But she's no hellraising Calamity Jane. The district panchayat president of Alirajpur and a PG degree holder in law is pursuing a doctorate from an Indore private university on crimes against children. Her husband is the state forest minister. Ratlam, with its high tribal population, is considered a Congress bastion but Anita managed to defeat GOP veteran Kantilal Bhuria by a 2-lakh margin.



RADHESHYAM RATHIA, *52*

| BJP | ***Raigarh (ST), Chhattisgarh***

Once represented by CM Vishnu Deo Sai, this was a prestige seat for the BJP. To renew its lease, it found none better than a quintessential organisation man who traced that same grassroots arc: deputy sarpanch in his village, district panchayat member, then janpad panchayat chief in Ghargh-hoda. Schooled in the ways of the BJP's ST Morcha, that was good enough to vanquish the Congress's Dr Menka Singh, of the erstwhile royal family of Raigarh.



BHARAT SUTARIYA, *53*

| BJP | ***Amreli, Gujarat***

Gujarat is happy hunting ground for debutants—as long as you're from the BJP. Just one year short of four obedient decades in the party wasn't enough to buy this district panchayat president a smooth journey to his first LS ticket: Amreli was shaken by protests against his nomination, incumbent MP Naranbhai Kachhadiya being the chief objecter. The party kept things in check for the Leuva Patel with a Class 10 certificate. Result: a victory margin of 3.2 lakh votes.

▼ D. MALAIYARASAN, *48*

| DMK | ***Kallakurichi, Tamil Nadu***



Under 'Administrative Experience', Malaiyarasan's CV lists only a decade (2006-16) as panchayat president. But the farmer with an M.Com in Banking and Insurance Management is dyed deep in the DMK's red and black: loyalties instilled right in childhood, and 31 years of graduating up the pecking order, right up to Parliament now. But victory was soon followed by a hooch tragedy that put Kallakurichi on the national news map. Deciding priorities won't be tough. Malaiyarasan beat Congress's R. Kumaraguru by over 50,000 votes.

–Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Moazum Mohammad, Rahul Noronha, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah, Amarnath K. Menon